1. Welcome, Purpose, and Policy Scope

Northstar Analytics Group is a fictional technology and analytics company. This handbook defines baseline employment practices for employees in the United States. It is intended for training and RAG testing and does not create a contract of employment.

Purpose

The handbook establishes consistent expectations for workplace conduct, time off, benefits administration, performance management, safety, travel, and other people-related practices.

Employment relationship

Unless a written agreement states otherwise and where permitted by law, employment is at will. Employees or the company may end employment at any time, subject to applicable law.

Policy updates

People Operations may revise policies when business, legal, or operational needs change. Material updates are communicated through the company intranet and email.

- Employees should read the handbook during onboarding.
- Managers are responsible for applying policies consistently.
- Questions should be directed to People Operations.

Applies to: All employees unless otherwise stated.
Policy owner: People Operations
Review cycle: Annual

2. Equal Employment Opportunity and Anti-Discrimination

Northstar provides equal employment opportunities and prohibits unlawful discrimination in recruiting, hiring, compensation, promotion, training, discipline, and separation.

Protected characteristics

Employment decisions must not be based on legally protected characteristics such as race, color, religion, sex, pregnancy, national origin, age, disability, genetic information, veteran status, or any other status protected by applicable law.

Reasonable accommodation

Employees may request reasonable workplace accommodations through People Operations. The company will engage in an interactive process and maintain confidentiality to the extent practical.

Non-retaliation

Retaliation against an employee who raises a good-faith concern, participates in an investigation, or requests an accommodation is prohibited.

- Report concerns promptly.
- Managers must escalate reports to People Operations.
- Confidentiality will be respected where possible.

Applies to: All employees unless otherwise stated.
Policy owner: People Operations
Review cycle: Annual

3. Anti-Harassment and Respectful Workplace

Harassment, bullying, intimidation, and other disrespectful behavior are inconsistent with Northstar's workplace standards.

Harassment

Prohibited conduct may include unwelcome verbal, visual, written, or physical behavior based on a protected characteristic when it creates an intimidating, hostile, or offensive work environment.

Sexual harassment

Unwelcome sexual advances, requests for sexual favors, or other conduct of a sexual nature are prohibited.

Reporting

Employees may report concerns to their manager, People Operations, or the confidential ethics channel. Employees are not required to report to a person involved in the concern.

- Do not retaliate against reporters or witnesses.
- Cooperate fully with investigations.
- Maintain professionalism in person and online.

Applies to: All employees unless otherwise stated.
Policy owner: People Operations
Review cycle: Annual

4. Work Hours, Attendance, and Timekeeping

Reliable attendance and accurate timekeeping support customer commitments and fair payroll practices.

Standard hours

Most corporate teams operate on a 40-hour workweek. Exact schedules may vary by function and location.

Attendance

Employees should notify their manager as soon as possible if they expect to be late or absent.

Timekeeping

Non-exempt employees must record all hours worked, meal periods where required, and approved leave. Working off the clock is prohibited.

Topic	Guideline
Core collaboration hours	10:00 AM-3:00 PM local time for teams that use flexible scheduling.
Meal breaks	Follow applicable state or local law and manager guidance.
Overtime	Must be approved in advance when required by policy.

Applies to: All employees unless otherwise stated.
Policy owner: People Operations
Review cycle: Annual

5. Paid Time Off and Vacation

Northstar provides paid time off to support rest, personal needs, and planned absences.

Accrual

Full-time employees accrue vacation each pay period. Accrual rates vary by tenure and job level.

Scheduling

Vacation should be requested in advance through the HR system. Managers consider coverage, project needs, and employee preferences.

Carryover

Employees may carry forward up to 80 hours of unused vacation into the next calendar year. Balances above 80 hours are forfeited unless local law requires otherwise.

Tenure	Annual Vacation Guideline
0-2 years	15 days
3-5 years	20 days
6+ years	25 days

Applies to: All employees unless otherwise stated.
Policy owner: People Operations
Review cycle: Annual

6. Sick Leave and Wellness Time

Paid sick leave may be used for an employee's illness, medical appointment, preventive care, or care of an eligible family member.

Notification

Employees should notify their manager before the start of the workday when reasonably possible.

Medical documentation

Documentation may be requested for extended absences where permitted by law.

Wellness days

Northstar provides two company-wide wellness days each calendar year in addition to regular holidays.

- Sick leave must not be used as vacation.
- Local sick-leave laws supersede this handbook where more generous.
- Employees should not work when illness creates a safety or public-health concern.

Applies to: All employees unless otherwise stated.
Policy owner: People Operations
Review cycle: Annual

7. Company Holidays

Northstar observes a standard U.S. holiday calendar and may designate additional floating holidays.

Eligibility

Regular full-time employees are eligible for paid company holidays.

Operations coverage

Teams supporting critical operations may use alternate holiday schedules.

Floating holidays

Two floating holidays may be used for cultural, religious, or personal observances with manager approval.

Holiday Type	Examples
Company-wide	New Year's Day, Memorial Day, Independence Day, Labor Day, Thanksgiving Day, Christmas Day
Floating	Two employee-selected days per year

Applies to: All employees unless otherwise stated.
Policy owner: People Operations
Review cycle: Annual

8. Family and Medical Leave

Eligible employees may take job-protected family or medical leave under federal, state, or local law and company policy.

Common reasons

Qualifying reasons may include an employee's serious health condition, care for an eligible family member, birth or placement of a child, or certain military-related circumstances.

Notice

Employees should provide advance notice when the need for leave is foreseeable.

Coordination

People Operations coordinates statutory leave, disability benefits, and available paid time where applicable.

- Leave eligibility depends on location, tenure, and hours worked.
- Medical information is handled confidentially.
- Contact People Operations before planning extended leave.

Applies to: All employees unless otherwise stated.
Policy owner: People Operations
Review cycle: Annual

9. Parental and Caregiver Leave

Northstar provides paid bonding leave for eligible employees following birth, adoption, or foster placement.

Parental leave

Eligible primary or secondary caregivers may receive up to 12 weeks of paid bonding leave.

Caregiver leave

Up to 10 paid days may be available each year for urgent caregiving situations involving an immediate family member.

Scheduling

Parental leave may be continuous or, with approval, taken intermittently in minimum one-week blocks.

- Use within 12 months of birth or placement.
- Coordinate with statutory benefits where applicable.
- Managers must not discourage eligible leave.

Applies to: All employees unless otherwise stated.
Policy owner: People Operations
Review cycle: Annual

10. Remote and Hybrid Work

Northstar supports flexible work arrangements when they align with role responsibilities, team collaboration, security requirements, and customer needs.

Hybrid expectation

Employees assigned to a hybrid role generally work from an approved office two days per week unless their team has a different documented schedule.

Remote workspace

Employees are responsible for maintaining a safe, private, and reliable workspace.

Location changes

Working from a different state or country for more than 10 consecutive business days requires advance approval due to tax, immigration, security, and payroll considerations.

- Protect confidential conversations from household members and visitors.
- Use company-managed devices for company work.
- Follow information-security policies at all times.

Applies to: All employees unless otherwise stated.
Policy owner: People Operations
Review cycle: Annual

11. Performance Management

Performance management is intended to align goals, clarify expectations, recognize contributions, and address development needs.

Goal setting

Employees and managers establish measurable goals at the beginning of each performance cycle.

Check-ins

Managers should hold regular one-on-one meetings and provide timely feedback.

Annual review

Formal reviews consider results, behaviors, collaboration, customer impact, and growth.

- Performance concerns should be discussed early.
- Improvement plans may be used when expectations are not being met.
- Employees may provide written comments on formal reviews.

Applies to: All employees unless otherwise stated.
Policy owner: People Operations
Review cycle: Annual

12. Compensation and Payroll

Northstar seeks to administer pay accurately, consistently, and in compliance with applicable wage-and-hour laws.

Pay schedule

Employees are paid semi-monthly on the 15th and last business day of each month.

Payroll changes

Employees should review pay statements and report suspected errors within 10 business days.

Deductions

Required taxes and authorized benefit deductions are withheld from pay.

- Direct deposit is the standard payment method.
- Compensation information should be handled discreetly, subject to employees' legal rights.
- Managers may not promise off-cycle raises without approval.

Applies to: All employees unless otherwise stated.
Policy owner: People Operations
Review cycle: Annual

13. Benefits Eligibility

Eligible employees may participate in health, retirement, and other benefit programs according to plan documents.

Eligibility

Most full-time employees become eligible for core health benefits on the first day of the month following hire.

Retirement

Eligible employees may contribute to the company-sponsored retirement plan, subject to plan rules.

Plan documents

Official plan documents control if there is any difference between this handbook and a benefit plan.

- Enrollment deadlines are communicated during onboarding.
- Life events may permit mid-year benefit changes.
- Employees should keep beneficiary information current.

Applies to: All employees unless otherwise stated.
Policy owner: People Operations
Review cycle: Annual

14. Learning, Certification, and Tuition Support

Northstar encourages ongoing learning that supports current responsibilities and future business needs.

Annual learning budget

Eligible employees may receive up to $2,500 per calendar year for approved courses, books, certifications, or conferences.

Tuition reimbursement

Degree-related reimbursement may be available up to $5,250 per year for approved programs.

Repayment

Certain high-cost programs may require repayment if the employee voluntarily leaves shortly after completion.

- Obtain written approval before incurring expenses.
- Learning should be relevant to the employee's role or development plan.
- Receipts and proof of completion are required.

Applies to: All employees unless otherwise stated.
Policy owner: People Operations
Review cycle: Annual

15. Business Travel and Expense Reimbursement

Employees should make reasonable, cost-conscious travel decisions while prioritizing safety and business needs.

Air travel

Economy class is standard for flights under six hours. Premium economy may be approved for longer flights.

Hotels

Use preferred hotels where available and stay within published city-rate guidelines.

Expense reports

Expense reports should be submitted within 30 days of travel or purchase.

- Itemized receipts are required for expenses of $25 or more.
- Personal expenses are not reimbursable.
- Alcohol is reimbursable only when part of an approved business meal and reasonable in amount.

Applies to: All employees unless otherwise stated.
Policy owner: People Operations
Review cycle: Annual

16. Workplace Safety and Emergency Response

Northstar is committed to providing a safe workplace and expects all employees to follow safety procedures.

Emergency procedures

Employees should know evacuation routes, emergency contacts, and assembly points for their assigned workplace.

Incident reporting

Workplace injuries, hazards, threats, or near misses should be reported promptly.

Fitness for work

Employees must not perform work while impaired in a manner that creates a safety risk.

- Do not block emergency exits.
- Follow building instructions during drills.
- Call emergency services first when immediate danger exists.

Applies to: All employees unless otherwise stated.
Policy owner: People Operations
Review cycle: Annual

17. Conflicts of Interest and Outside Activities

Employees must avoid situations in which personal interests conflict, or appear to conflict, with Northstar's interests.

Financial interests

Employees should disclose significant financial interests in customers, suppliers, or competitors when relevant to their work.

Outside employment

Outside work is allowed if it does not interfere with job duties, misuse company resources, or create a conflict.

Gifts

Employees may not accept gifts or entertainment intended to improperly influence a business decision.

- Disclose potential conflicts early.
- Seek guidance before accepting substantial gifts.
- Do not use confidential information for personal gain.

Applies to: All employees unless otherwise stated.
Policy owner: People Operations
Review cycle: Annual

18. Confidentiality and Intellectual Property

Employees may access confidential business, customer, employee, and technical information and must protect it.

Confidential information

Examples include non-public financial information, source code, customer data, pricing, roadmaps, security details, and personnel information.

Need to know

Access and sharing should be limited to legitimate business need.

Work product

Inventions and work product created within the scope of employment may belong to Northstar subject to applicable agreements and law.

- Do not forward company files to personal email.
- Use approved storage locations.
- Return or delete company information when employment ends, as directed.

Applies to: All employees unless otherwise stated.
Policy owner: People Operations
Review cycle: Annual

19. Corrective Action and Separation

Northstar may use coaching, warnings, performance plans, suspension, or termination depending on the circumstances.

Progressive discipline

The company may use progressive steps but is not required to follow a fixed sequence.

Resignation

Employees are encouraged to provide at least two weeks' notice.

Final pay and property

Final pay is provided according to law. Employees must return company devices, badges, documents, and other property.

- Serious misconduct may result in immediate termination.
- Access may be disabled before or at separation.
- Exit interviews may be offered.

Applies to: All employees unless otherwise stated.
Policy owner: People Operations
Review cycle: Annual

20. Acknowledgment, Contacts, and Revision History

Employees are responsible for understanding applicable policies and asking questions when guidance is unclear.

Key contacts

People Operations handles employment policy questions; IT handles technical support; Security handles security incidents; Ethics handles confidential concerns.

Acknowledgment

Electronic acknowledgment confirms receipt of the handbook, not agreement to a contract.

Revision history

This fictional edition is Version 1.0, effective January 1, 2027, created solely for testing retrieval systems.

Contact	Purpose
People Operations	Benefits, leave, accommodations, employee relations
IT Service Desk	Devices, accounts, software support
Security Operations	Security incidents and suspicious activity
Ethics Channel	Confidential reporting of misconduct

Applies to: All employees unless otherwise stated.
Policy owner: People Operations
Review cycle: Annual